Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

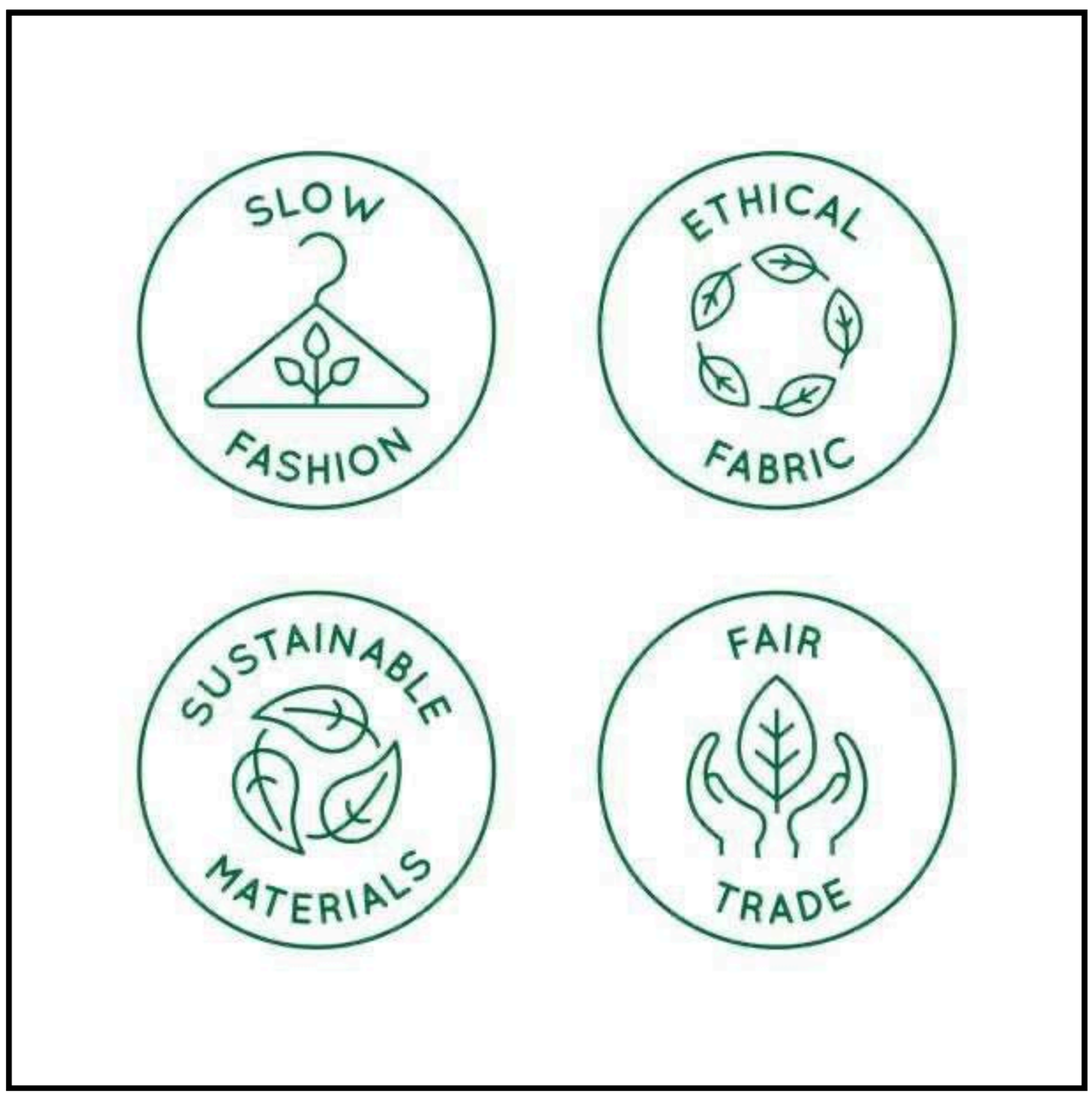
November 2024

A HARVEST YOU CAN WEAR



As the harmful impact of synthetic dyes on health and the environment gets more widely reported, natural dyes, the earth's oldest and kindest colourants, are making a rapid comeback.

These dyes are obtained largely from renewable botanical sources – berries, bark, leaves, flowers, roots, seeds, wood, even fungi and lichen. This makes them safer than synthetic colourants, gentle on the skin and gentle on the planet.



Using natural dyes also helps to save water because harvested plants can be used directly for dyeing without the wasteful process of chemical production. Besides, natural dyes do not only avoid toxins, they don't release them either, and the residue is biodegradable.



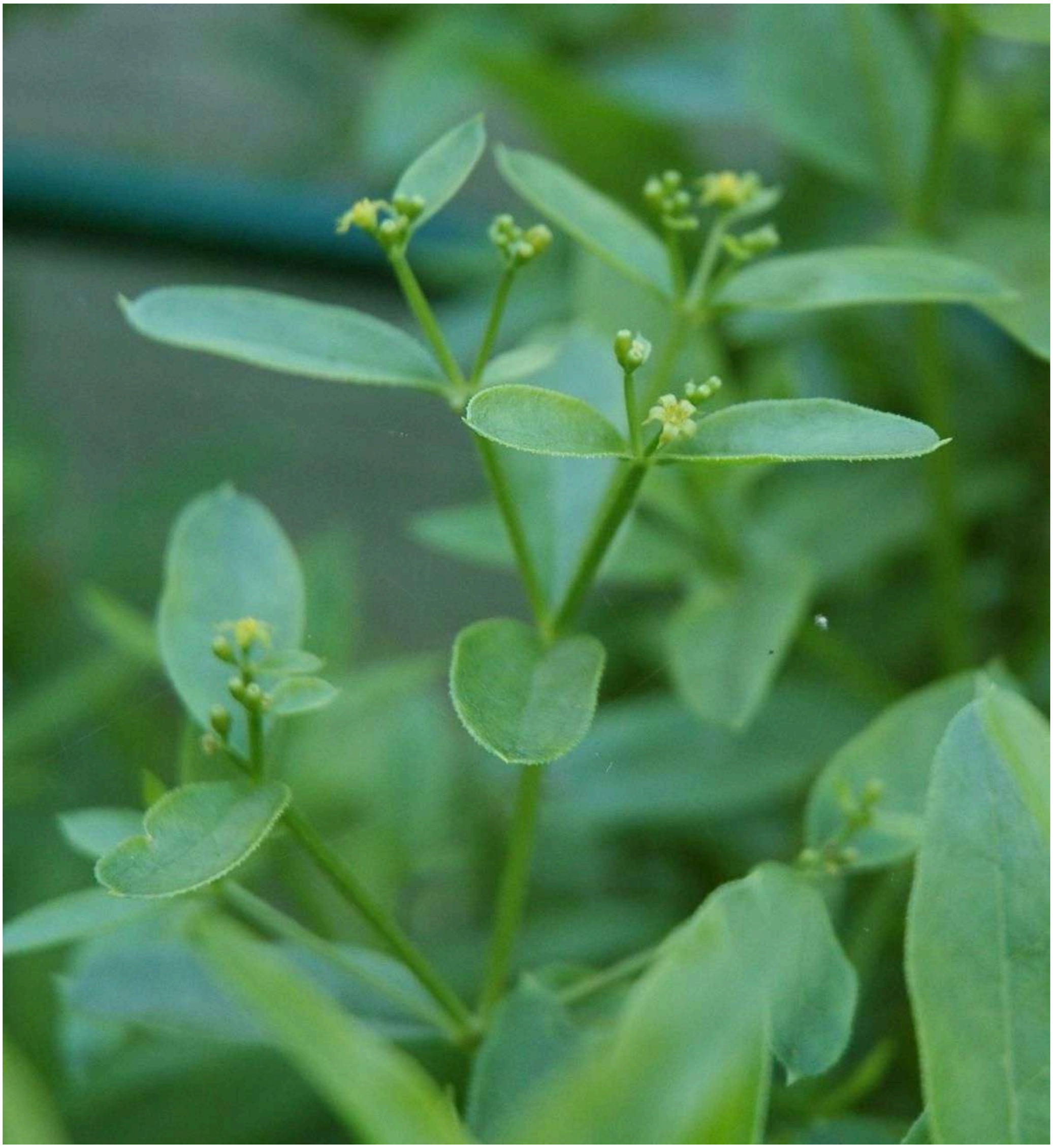
Almost all countries have innumerable plant (and mineral) sources of dyes. Here are some that are native to India and popular.



Marigold

(genda/banti puvvu/one of many kinds of saamandhi)

The many varieties of this showy farm crop yield colours from orange to golden yellow to ochre, even a mossy green and a light tan.



Madder

(manjishtha/majith/manditti)
is a perennial whose roots
produce a vibrant red dye.
Madder has been cultivated for
centuries across civilisations and
has a rich history in textile dyeing.



Henna

(mehndi/marudhani)
produces a dark tan tending towards red-orange on certain fibres. The dye comes from the leaves that are sun-dried and ground to a powder.



Indigo

(neel ka paudha/avuri)

A number of plants produce the deep blue colour we all know, but the age-old, most widely cultivated variety is indigofera, native to the tropics, predominantly India. It is one of the oldest dyestuffs still in use. Fun fact: it was the original dye of the iconic blue of denim fabric.



Cutch

(kattha)

derived from the wood of the acacia catechu tree is a precious source of colourfast shades of cinnamon, nutmeg and clove. The wood is steeped in hot water till a syrupy liquid emerges, which is used in the preparation of chewable betel leaves. The remaining plentiful woody pulp is the by-product used for dyeing textiles and paper and for water softening. Now that is one earth-friendly tree that keeps on giving.



Myrobalan

(kadukka/harad/haritaki)

are small ribbed nutlike fruits

(with uses for gut health in natural medicine.) They impart a light buttery yellow dye that is used both on its own and to tan cotton fabric evenly before overlaying with other colours.



Pomegranate

(anaar/madhulam)

A powder made from the rind of the fruit yields soft yellows to green-yellows. Being high in tannin, it improves uniformly the ‘washfastness’ of any dye with which it is mixed, and can produce pleasing hues from silvery greys to bottle and emerald green.

Some enduring textiles reveal how long natural dyes can last



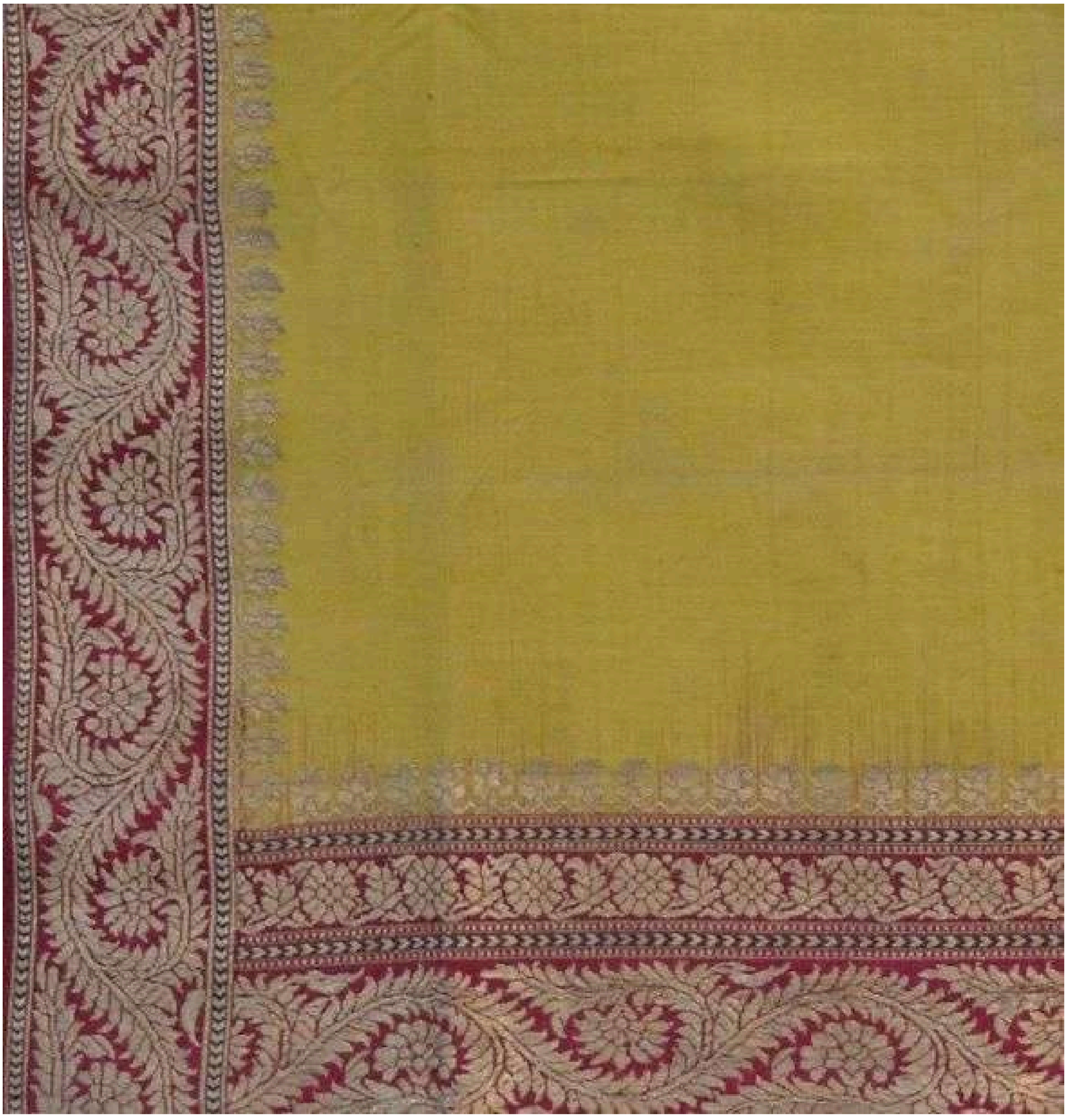
Naga man’s shawl 1940s, using osak, the leafy Assam indigo plant



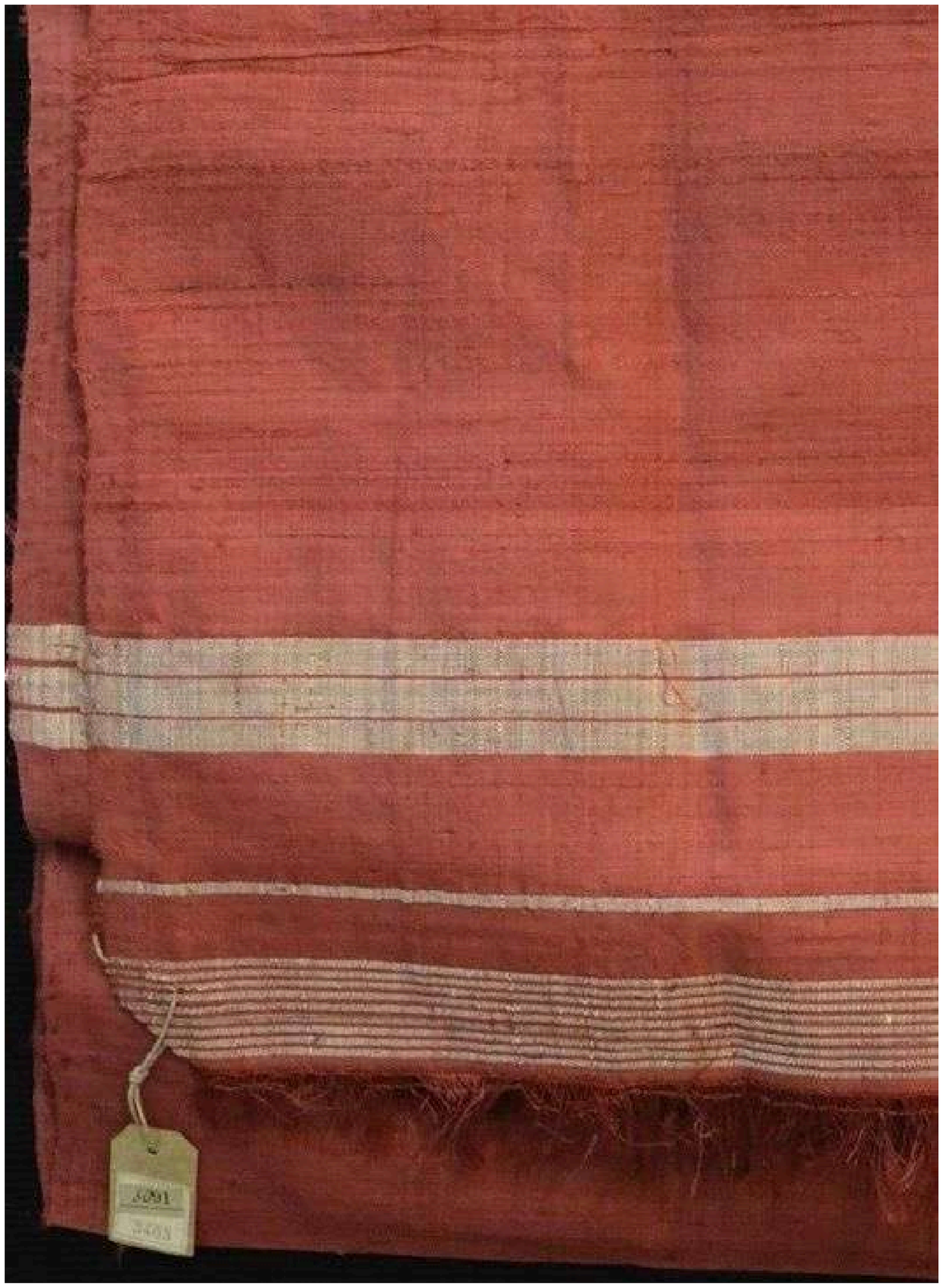
Patola saree dyed with turmeric.
Patan, Gujarat, early 20thC



Embroidered bed-hanging with lac-dyed silk thread.
Gujarat, circa 1700, V&A



Ritual yellow ‘pitambar’ dhoti,
dyed with larkspur.
Varanasi, 1852, V&A



Muga shawl dyed with lac.

Sibsagar, Assam, 1855

Fast forward to today. Floral waste, a new source of eco-friendly natural dyes, is making waves in India. See how in this 7-min video.